

same sort of utilities to draw diagrams.

QFX7, for once, did not disappoint the user. By activating the draw mode one can draw free form diagrams with the pencil tool and unlike the paint mode, one can work on layers in the draw mode. It also equips the user with different brush strokes and sizes and one can increase or decrease the softness of the strokes.

Jasc Paint Shop Pro's tools are quite similar to Photoshop—the pencil for free hand drawing, a clone brush to clone objects, a paint brush, air brush, etc. And work is just fine though it isn't as customisable as Adobe Photoshop. An interesting feature here is the colourful picture tube, which allows you to paint full colour random thumbnail images.

Image formats: Depending on the use that is to be made of the image, say print or Web, you will need to choose a suitable image format. This also has an impact on the file size of the image. For example, if one imports an image, does the appropriate work and saves the image as a TIFF (tagged information file format) file, then this high-resolution image will cost a few MBs of hard disk space.

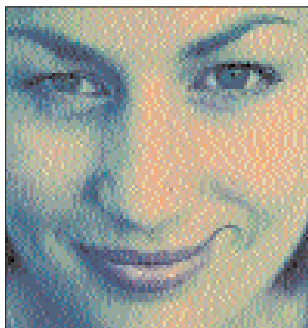
Proprietary file formats such as Adobe's PSD can offer quite a lot of added benefits in terms of saving the image in its original and perfectly editable format, but it surely isn't the optimal format for delivering files to other people, or for that matter, using the image on the Web.

While using proprietary formats, you can save all the layers, vectors and text separately and in its true editable form, and re-use it as you wish. Adobe Photoshop, Jasc Paint Shop Pro and QFX7 allow one to save the image in various formats, including the most common ones like .jpg, .gif and .psd. Gimp doesn't support saving the image in .gif and .tiff format, whereas Micrografx only supports .ppf and .bmp formats. However, it does allow one to export the image and apply JPEG and GIF compressions but it cannot save them in that format.

Additional features: Most of the software had some additional features that added a punch to the functionality. Adobe Photoshop 6.01 has a new feature called 'Liquify', which allows you to do some amazing things such as selecting a particular portion of the image and bloating it, twirling it clockwise and anti-clockwise, shifting pixels, and thawing and freezing it.

The Type tool of Photoshop has improved dramatically. The text can now

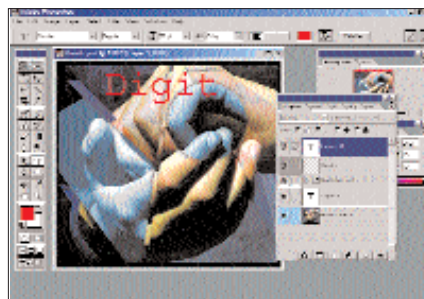
be edited onscreen directly instead of having to open another text-editing



Wonders achieved through the Liquify tool of Photoshop 6

window, which is the norm in the other software.

Features such as adding notes or audio annotations in an image editing software



In Photoshop 6, you can edit text on screen

might appear strange but can be very useful when the same file is modified from time to time. It's nice to have the ability to add active comments to an image, just like a word document, if it is sent for approval

or review to another person. Hence, with the facility of adding notes and audio annotations, one can record comments and send it across.

For drawing lines, circles and other such objects and text, vector support is helpful for scaling the image or that particular component of the image whenever the need arises.

Help!

Help files will always be accessed, whether it is a novice at work, an intermediate user or a professional. The help files of QFX7 are self explanatory though not as elaborate as one would expect.

Jasc Paint Shop Pro provides the user with extremely detailed help such as explaining the basic fundamentals of



Micrografx Publisher provides help through visuals

image editing and how to go about working with each and every feature of the software. This makes things easier as it supports context-sensitive help.

Gimp also supports context-sensitive

Effects Galore

"Oh God, how can one possibly do that?"

Now you will get the answer to that question and many more whenever you see a startling image with a fiery finish or water droplets suspended in air with some crazed-out effect.

The answer lies in plugins. There are various plugins available for download (shareware as well as freeware) and users can install them in the same directory where the image editing software is. Some popular plugins are KPT and Eyecandy, which are used by many people in the industry.



Eyecandy's fire effect

Here's where you can get some popular plugins:

Shareware

Dream Suite from auto fx software

(www.auotfx.com)

Eyecandy and Xenofex

from Alien Skin (www.alien-skin.com)

KPT from Corel

(www3.corel.com)

Intellihance Pro, Mask Pro and Photo Frame from www.extensis.com

Freeware

Filter Factory Galleries from <http://showcase.netins.net/web/wolf359/plugins.htm>

Media Spark Filters from www.mediaspark.com